

5.8 History Cleaners

5.8.1 Introduction

Any browsing activity leaves a trail on the system. Temporary file folders, browser history, browser address bar, browser profile assistant, and the Registry are some places where it is possible to find information that can be used to piece together a user's browsing history. History cleaners are a group of applications that can delete the relevant information from these locations and make it difficult to find where the user has been. On a "personal" computer, with all security paraphernalia installed, a user can remain relatively protected. But when the need to access the Net over a public PC arises, the following tools can become imperative.

5.8.2 CCleaner

This is comprehensive history cleaner. It can clean the trails of all three major browsers—Opera, IE, and Firefox. And while it is at it, it can also clean the usage history of commonly-used applications like Office 2003, WinRAR, Adobe Flash Player, and Windows Media Player. It can also erase many other chunks of data that are no longer relevant—like broken shortcut link and Registry entries, thus contributing to a leaner system.



The results of a CCleaner scan

By default, CCleaner looks at all the locations where browsers and the OS leave information. The user can select which areas to ignore, if needed.

Under the Registry and Tools section, there are additional cleaning options available. Under the Options section, the user can manually specify any other folder or file that CCleaner should erase along with the rest.